



THE PRACTICAL PLAYBOOK

The 90-Day Social Media Growth Guide

for Local Businesses

Turn followers into customers in 90 days

90-DAY ROADMAP • 9 MODULES • CHECKLISTS • TEMPLATES

By Andrew Corter, Founder and CEO of Corter Digital

corterdigital.com



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Before You Start

Most local business owners don't struggle with social media because they're lazy or bad at it. They struggle because they're running a business at the same time. There's no marketing team, no budget for an agency, and the advice online is written for influencers and national brands, not for the bakery, the plumber, the salon, or the gym down the street.

This guide is different. Every module is built for one goal: **getting people who live near you to walk in, call, or book**. Not going viral. Not collecting followers in other countries. Customers.

How to use this guide

- **Follow the 90-Day Roadmap** at the back of this guide. It splits the nine modules into three 30-day phases, with clear tasks for every week. Trying to fix everything at once is the fastest way to quit.
- **Record your Day 1 numbers** before you start (see the monthly scorecard in Module 9), so you can see exactly how far you've come at Day 90.
- **Finish every "Do This Today" checklist** before moving on. Reading without doing changes nothing.
- **Steal the templates**. The scripts, bios, caption formulas and replies are meant to be copied and adapted.
- **Come back to it**. Modules 4 to 7 are worth rereading whenever your content feels stuck.

Your 90 days at a glance

Phase	Focus	Modules
Days 1 to 30	Build the foundation. Know your customer, choose your platforms, and set up profiles that get found and make it easy to buy.	1, 2, 3, and start 4
Days 31 to 60	Create and get seen. Build a content system you can keep up with, and start reaching more local people.	4, 5, 6
Days 61 to 90	Convert and grow. Turn attention into customers, build your reputation, and measure what's working.	7, 8, 9

What's inside

Module	What it solves
1. Know Your Local Customer	Posting into the void without knowing who you're talking to
2. Choosing Your Platforms	Trying to be everywhere and burning out
3. Profiles That Get Found Locally	People nearby can't find you, or can't figure out how to buy

Module	What it solves
4. What to Post	Staring at a blank screen with no ideas
5. Creating Content With No Time	No time, no budget, and hating being on camera
6. Getting Seen	Posting consistently and getting almost no views
7. Turning Followers Into Customers	Likes and views that never turn into sales
8. Reviews, Reputation and Community	Too few reviews, fear of bad ones, and feeling invisible locally
9. Small-Budget Ads and Measuring	Wasting money on ads and not knowing what's working

IF YOU'RE SHORT ON TIME

If you only have time for three things this month: complete your Google Business Profile (Module 2), fix your bio and contact buttons (Module 3), and start asking every happy customer for a review (Module 8). Those three alone will bring in more local business than months of random posting.



MODULE 01

Know Your Local Customer

Stop posting for "everyone." Get crystal clear on who actually buys from you, where they spend their time online, and why a small local audience is worth more than a big one.

IN THIS MODULE

- 1.1 Building a simple local customer profile
- 1.2 Where your customers spend time online
- 1.3 Why local followers beat big follower counts

1.1 Building a Simple Local Customer Profile

You don't need a fancy marketing persona. You need a one-page snapshot of the people who already pay you, so every post you make is aimed at someone real. The best source isn't guesswork. It's your existing customers, your receipts, and your booking history.

Answer these seven questions

Question	Example: neighborhood coffee shop
Who buys most often?	Remote workers aged 25 to 45, parents after school drop-off, nurses from the nearby clinic
Where do they live or work?	Within about 2 miles; many walk or bike
When do they buy?	7 to 9am weekdays, a second rush at 3pm, brunch crowd on weekends
Why do they choose you?	Quiet place to work, friendly staff who know their order, good pastries
What almost stopped them?	Didn't know there was parking; thought it was pricey
What do they care about locally?	The farmers market, school events, the new bike lane, supporting local
What words do they use?	"cozy," "good wifi," "best cortado in town" (pulled from their reviews)

QUICK WIN

Talk to your 10 best customers this week. Ask: *"How did you first hear about us?"* and *"What would you tell a friend about us?"* Their exact words become your captions, bio and ad copy.

Also read your own reviews, and your competitors' reviews. Positive reviews tell you what people value. Negative reviews of competitors tell you what frustrates customers, and what you can promise instead.

1.2 Where Your Customers Spend Time Online

Your customers aren't "on social media." They're on specific apps, in specific groups, doing specific things. A retiree looking for a handyman and a 22-year-old looking for a new brunch spot behave completely differently. Find out where your people actually are before you spend time anywhere.

Four ways to find out

- **Ask at checkout or booking.** Add "How did you hear about us?" to your booking form, intake sheet or till. Tally it for a month.
- **Check where your reviews live.** If most reviews are on Google and Facebook, those are the places your customers already interact with you.
- **Study engaged competitors.** Look at who comments on similar local businesses. Are they on Instagram? In Facebook groups? Posting on TikTok?

- **Search local communities.** Look for your town's Facebook groups, Nextdoor, and local subreddits. Search for your service. If people are asking for recommendations there, that's where you need to be visible.

A rough starting point

If your customers are mostly...	Start by looking at...
Homeowners and families (trades, home services, dentists)	Google, Facebook, local Facebook groups, Nextdoor
Younger adults (cafes, bars, fitness, beauty)	Instagram, TikTok, Google Maps
Visually-driven buyers (florists, bakeries, boutiques, interiors)	Instagram, Pinterest, Google
Business clients (accountants, B2B services)	Google, LinkedIn, local business networks

These are starting points, not rules. Your own customers' answers always win.

1.3 Why Local Followers Beat Big Follower Counts

A hair salon with 600 followers who live within 10 miles will make more money than one with 15,000 followers scattered around the world. For a local business, **the only followers that matter are ones who can physically become customers.**

There's also a hidden cost to the wrong followers. Platforms show your posts to people similar to those who already engage. If your audience is full of out-of-towners, giveaway hunters or bought followers, the algorithm learns to show your content to more of the wrong people, and your local reach shrinks.

Avoid these follower traps

- **Buying followers or engagement.** It inflates numbers, kills real reach, and breaks platform rules.
- **"Follow, like and tag 3 friends" giveaways with no local requirement.** They attract prize hunters, not customers. If you run one, require local pickup or an in-store visit to claim.
- **Chasing trends that have nothing to do with your business or town.** A viral video that brings 5,000 non-local followers can actually hurt you.

Check your local share

In Instagram, Facebook and TikTok insights, look for your audience's **top cities or locations**. Aim for the majority of your audience to be in your town and the surrounding area. Track this number every month. It's more important than your total follower count.

DO THIS TODAY

- Answer the seven customer profile questions and save them on one page.
- Ask 10 regular customers how they found you and what they'd tell a friend.
- Add "How did you hear about us?" to your checkout, booking form or intake sheet.
- Find and join 2 or 3 local online communities (Facebook groups, Nextdoor, local subreddit).
- Check your top audience locations in your current social insights and write down the percentage that's local.



MODULE 02

Choosing Your Platforms (and Ignoring the Rest)

You don't need to be everywhere. You need to be excellent in one or two places your customers actually use, built on top of the one platform every local business needs.

IN THIS MODULE

- 2.1 Platform breakdown: which fits which business
- 2.2 Google Business Profile as your foundation
- 2.3 The one-to-two platform rule for limited time

2.1 Platform Breakdown

Each platform rewards a different kind of content and attracts a different kind of user. Use this table to shortlist, then confirm with what you learned about your customers in Module 1.

Platform	Best for	What works there	Weekly time
Google Business Profile	Every local business, no exceptions	Photos, updates, offers, reviews, accurate info	15 to 30 min
Instagram	Food, beauty, fitness, retail, venues, anything visual	Reels, carousels, stories, behind-the-scenes	2 to 4 hrs
Facebook	Services, trades, older audiences, community-focused businesses	Local groups, events, reviews, video, updates	1 to 3 hrs
TikTok	Personality-led businesses, younger audiences, anything with a process to show	Short, authentic, fast-paced video	2 to 4 hrs
Nextdoor	Home services, trades, pet care, neighborhood shops	Recommendations, local offers, neighborly posts	30 min
YouTube Shorts	Reusing your vertical videos for extra reach	Same videos as Reels and TikTok	15 min
LinkedIn	Professional and B2B services	Expertise, local business relationships	1 to 2 hrs
Pinterest	Weddings, home decor, design, events	Inspiring images that link to your site	1 hr

2.2 Google Business Profile: Your Foundation

When someone searches "coffee near me" or "emergency electrician [your town]," your Google Business Profile is often the first thing they see. These people aren't scrolling for fun. **They're ready to buy right now.** That makes Google the highest-value "social" platform most local businesses have, and the most neglected.

The complete-profile checklist

- **Primary category:** choose the most specific one available ("Italian restaurant," not "Restaurant"). Add relevant secondary categories.
- **Hours:** accurate regular hours, plus special hours for holidays. Wrong hours cost you customers and trust.
- **Services or products:** list each one with a short description and price range where it makes sense.
- **Photos:** exterior (so people recognize you), interior, team, products, and work in progress. Add new photos monthly.

- **Business description:** what you do, who you serve and which areas, in plain language.
- **Contact and booking:** phone number, website, booking or ordering link, and messaging if you can respond quickly.
- **Updates and offers:** post an update, offer or event regularly so your profile looks active.
- **Reviews:** reply to every one (Module 8 shows you how).

QUICK WIN

Search for your own business on Google Maps from your phone as if you were a new customer. Can you tell within 10 seconds what you do, whether you're open, and how to contact you? If not, fix that first.

Google changes the features available on business profiles from time to time. If an option mentioned here isn't available for your business, skip it and focus on the rest.

2.3 The One-to-Two Platform Rule

Here's the rule: **Google Business Profile plus one main social platform.** Add a second only when the first is running smoothly without stress. A business that posts well on one platform will always beat a business that posts badly on five.

Pick your main platform

If this sounds like you...	Make this your main platform
Your product or result looks great in photos and video	Instagram
Your customers are mostly 40+, or your business is rooted in the community	Facebook
You (or a staff member) have personality and don't mind being a bit playful	TikTok
You go to people's homes or serve a specific neighborhood	Facebook, plus Nextdoor
You serve other businesses or professionals	LinkedIn

WORK SMARTER: POST ONCE, SHARE EVERYWHERE

Film one short vertical video, then post it as an Instagram Reel, a TikTok, a YouTube Short and a Facebook Reel. Same video, four places, a few extra minutes. This is the easiest way to extend your reach without creating more content. Just remove any watermark from one app before uploading to another.

DO THIS TODAY

- Claim or log in to your Google Business Profile.
- Work through the complete-profile checklist above and fill every gap.
- Choose your one main social platform using the table above, and write down why.
- Pause or archive accounts you can't keep active. An abandoned profile looks like a closed business.



MODULE 03

Setting Up Profiles That Get Found Locally

Your profile is your shopfront. Make it instantly clear what you do, where you are, and how to become a customer in one tap.

IN THIS MODULE

- 3.1** Writing a bio that says who, what and where
- 3.2** Local keywords, location tags and categories
- 3.3** Contact buttons, links and booking setup

3.1 Writing a Bio That Says Who, What and Where

Most people decide whether to follow or contact you in a few seconds. A clever bio that doesn't say what you do loses them. Clear beats clever every time.

The local bio formula

FORMULA

What you do + who it's for + where + one line of proof or personality + call to action

Business	Example bio
Bakery	Sourdough, cakes and coffee in downtown Maple Falls. Baked fresh at 5am daily. Order celebration cakes below.
Plumber	Licensed plumbing and emergency repairs across Tacoma and Puyallup. 24/7 callouts. Upfront pricing. Tap to call.
Salon	Color specialists in Northside. Lived-in blondes and curly cuts. 4.9 stars from 300+ reviews. Book online below.
Gym	Small-group strength training for busy adults in Riverton. First class free. Tap the link to book.

- **Use the same username everywhere** if you can, ideally your business name.
- **Put a keyword in your name field.** On Instagram, the name field is searchable, so "Rosa's Bakery | Maple Falls Cakes" gets found more than "Rosa's."
- **Use a clear profile picture:** your logo if it's simple, or your face if you *are* the brand. Make sure it reads at a tiny size.

3.2 Local Keywords, Location Tags and Categories

Platforms work like search engines. People search "nails [town]," "brunch near me," or "dog groomer [neighborhood]." Help platforms connect you to those searches.

Where to use local keywords

- **Your bio and name field:** your town or neighborhood plus your main service.
- **Your captions:** mention your town, nearby landmarks and neighborhoods naturally ("Just finished a kitchen repair in Westside").
- **On-screen text and spoken words in videos:** many platforms read and search these too.
- **Alt text for images** where the option exists, describing the photo and location.
- **Google Business Profile:** your description, services and updates.

Location tags and categories

- **Tag your location on every post and story** where the option exists. Also try tagging your town or neighborhood on some posts to show up in location searches.

- **Set your business category** on Instagram, Facebook and Google to the most specific option.
- **Use a few relevant local hashtags** (e.g. #MapleFallsEats) rather than dozens of generic ones. Hashtags matter less than they used to; keywords in captions often matter more.

QUICK WIN

Keep your business name, address and phone number exactly the same on every platform and directory. Consistent details help Google trust your listing, and help customers find you.

3.3 Contact Buttons, Links and Booking Setup

Every extra step between "I'm interested" and "I've booked" loses customers. Your job is to remove friction.

- **Turn on action buttons:** Call, Email, Directions, Book, Order, depending on what the platform offers. Choose the one action that matters most to your business.
- **Use a simple link page** in your bio with no more than 3 to 5 links: book or order, menu or price list, reviews, location. Put the most important link first.
- **Connect booking tools** directly where possible so people can book without leaving the app.
- **Show your prices or a starting price** if you can. "From \$45" answers the question that stops many people from contacting you.

THE 60-SECOND TEST

Ask a friend who has never been to your business to go from your Instagram or Google profile to a confirmed booking or order while you watch. Time it. If it takes more than 60 seconds, or they get confused at any point, fix that step.

DO THIS TODAY

- Rewrite your bio using the local bio formula.
- Add your town plus main service to your name field or profile title where possible.
- Check your business name, address and phone number match exactly across all platforms.
- Turn on the right contact or booking button on each profile.
- Run the 60-second test with a friend and fix whatever slows them down.



MODULE 04

What to Post When You Don't Know What to Post

You'll never run out of ideas again. Learn the four types of content that work for local businesses, and how to find posts hiding in your ordinary workday.

IN THIS MODULE

- 4.1 The 4 content pillars for local businesses
- 4.2 Turning everyday work into content
- 4.3 A 50-idea bank for when you're stuck
- 4.4 Tapping into local events, seasons and news

4.1 The 4 Content Pillars for Local Businesses

Content pillars are the few categories that all your posts fall into. They stop you staring at a blank screen, and they keep your feed balanced so it's not just ads. For local businesses, four pillars cover almost everything.

Pillar	Purpose	Examples
SHOW	Build trust by letting people see behind the scenes	How things are made, prep, the process, setup, a day in the life
TEACH	Show expertise and be genuinely useful	Tips, FAQs, mistakes to avoid, how to choose, care instructions
PROVE	Remove doubt with evidence	Reviews, before/after, results, customer stories, awards
BELONG	Show you're part of the community	Staff spotlights, local events, shout-outs to neighbors, customer features

Rotate through the pillars across the week. Then, roughly **one post in five can be a direct promotion**: an offer, a new product, "we have slots this Friday." When the other four posts have built trust, the promotional one works much better.

A SIMPLE WEEK

Mon: SHOW (morning prep time-lapse) • Wed: TEACH ("3 things to ask before booking a...") • Fri: PROVE (customer review turned into a graphic) • Sat: BELONG (shout-out to the market next door) • Every other week, swap one for a PROMO post.

4.2 Turning Everyday Work Into Content

The biggest mindset shift: **document, don't create**. You don't need to invent content. You need to capture what already happens every day. What feels boring to you is often fascinating to customers, because they never get to see it.

Business	Everyday moments worth filming
Restaurant or cafe	Opening routine, plating a dish, the first coffee of the day, the delivery arriving, the chef's staff meal
Salon or barber	Transformations, product explanations, the consultation, tool cleaning, client reactions (with permission)
Trades and home services	Before/after, finding the problem, the tools, the van setup, "what I found behind this wall"

Business	Everyday moments worth filming
Retail or boutique	Unboxing new stock, styling one item three ways, window display changes, packing orders
Fitness studio	Coaching cues, member wins, class setup, one exercise done right vs wrong
Professional services	Common client questions answered, deadlines to know, a quick explainer, office life

QUICK WIN

Create a note on your phone called "Content Ideas." Every time a customer asks a question, says something funny, or you do something interesting at work, add it. In a month you'll have more ideas than you can use.

4.3 A 50-Idea Bank for When You're Stuck

Use this list whenever you run dry. Each idea works for almost any local business with a small tweak.

Pillar	Ideas
SHOW	Your opening routine • How your best-seller is made • A time-lapse of a busy day • Your workspace tour • Your tools or equipment explained • Packing or preparing an order • What happens after a customer books • Setting up for a big weekend • A mistake and how you fixed it • Why you started the business
TEACH	The #1 question customers ask • 3 mistakes people make with [topic] • How to choose the right [product] • A myth in your industry, busted • How to make [product] last longer • What to expect at a first visit • Price explained: what goes into it • A quick tip in under 15 seconds • Seasonal care advice • "Is it worth it?" honest answers
PROVE	A before and after • A 5-star review read aloud • A customer's story • A number that matters (e.g. 1,000 cakes baked) • Repeat customers' favorite items • A problem solved, start to finish • Behind a tough job • Your guarantee explained • Awards or local press • A customer's photo, reshared
BELONG	Staff spotlight • Meet the owner • Shout-out to a neighboring business • Your favorite local spots • A local event you're attending • Customer of the month • Your team's lunch order • A charity or school you support • Your town's history or a landmark • Answering a local question
PROMO	New product or service launch • Limited slots this week • A seasonal special • A first-visit offer • Gift card reminder before holidays • A new booking system • Holiday hours • A last-minute cancellation slot • A bundle or package • A reminder of your best-seller

4.4 Tapping Into Local Events, Seasons and News

Local businesses have a huge advantage national brands can't copy: you're actually *here*. Content tied to your town gets shared more, because people love seeing their own community.

- **Build a local calendar** at the start of each quarter: festivals, markets, school terms, sports seasons, holidays, community fundraisers.
- **Follow the seasons:** weather changes, school runs, tourist season, holiday shopping. Each one changes what customers need.
- **React to local moments:** the local team winning, the first snow, a new park opening, road closures that affect access.
- **Use "insider" content:** "Our favorite spots in [town]" and "where to park near us" posts are very shareable.

A WORD OF CAUTION

Stay clear of divisive local politics and controversial debates. The goal is to be the business everyone in town feels good about, not to pick sides.

DO THIS TODAY

- Write your four pillars at the top of your content notes, with 3 ideas under each.
- Create your "Content Ideas" phone note and add 5 everyday moments from your business.
- Pick 5 ideas from the 50-idea bank for next week.
- List the local events and seasonal moments coming up in the next 3 months.



MODULE 05

Creating Content With No Time, Budget or Camera Confidence

Professional-looking content from your phone, formats that don't require showing your face, and a system for a week's worth of posts in about an hour.

IN THIS MODULE

- 5.1 Phone-only photo and video basics
- 5.2 Faceless and hands-only content formats
- 5.3 Batching a week of content in one hour
- 5.4 Templates and free tools that speed things up

5.1 Phone-Only Photo and Video Basics

The phone in your pocket is enough. Local customers don't want polished ads; they want to see the real business. A few basics make the difference between "amateur" and "authentic."

Basic	What to do
Clean the lens	Wipe it before every shoot. A smudged lens is the #1 cause of hazy, blurry content.
Use natural light	Face a window or shoot outside in shade. Avoid harsh overhead lights and backlighting.
Shoot vertical	Hold your phone upright for Reels, TikTok, Shorts and stories.
Lock focus and exposure	Tap and hold on your subject so the camera doesn't keep adjusting.
Keep it steady	Lean on a counter, prop the phone up, or use a cheap tripod or clamp.
Get clear audio	Get closer to the phone, film in a quiet spot, or use a small clip-on mic. Bad audio loses viewers faster than bad video.
Film short clips	Record 3 to 5 second clips from different angles. Short clips are easier to edit into a fast-paced video.
Grab B-roll	Film extra shots of hands working, products and your space. Use them as background footage for voiceovers.

5.2 Faceless and Hands-Only Content Formats

Plenty of successful local accounts rarely show a face. If being on camera stops you from posting, use these formats instead.

- **Hands-only process videos:** decorating, cutting, repairing, assembling, pouring. Satisfying and easy.
- **POV (point of view) videos:** film from your eye level. "POV: you're opening a bakery at 5am."
- **Before and afters:** the result does all the talking.
- **Voiceover on B-roll:** record your voice explaining a tip over footage of your work. Nobody sees you.
- **Text-on-screen videos:** a hook and a few lines of text over footage, set to background music.
- **Photo carousels:** step-by-step photos, or a tip broken into 5 slides.
- **Feature your team or customers** (with their permission) if they're more comfortable on camera than you.

If you do want to show up on camera

- Write three bullet points, not a full script. Reading word-for-word looks stiff.
- Record three takes and post the best one. The first take is always the worst.
- Talk to the camera like it's one regular customer, not "everyone."

- Remember: viewers judge far less harshly than you do. Showing up regularly matters more than being polished.

5.3 Batching a Week of Content in One Hour

Creating content every day is draining and easy to skip. Batching means doing the same type of task all at once. One focused hour per week can cover everything.

Step	Time	What you do
1. Plan	10 min	Pick 3 to 5 ideas from your idea bank and pillars. Write a hook for each.
2. Film	25 min	During a quiet period, film all clips and photos at once. Grab extra B-roll.
3. Edit	15 min	Trim clips, add text and music in an editing app. Use your saved templates.
4. Caption and schedule	10 min	Write captions using the formula below and schedule everything for the week.

QUICK WIN

Block the hour in your calendar like a client appointment, same time every week. Pick your quietest time, such as Tuesday at 2pm or before opening on Monday.

5.4 Templates and Free Tools That Speed Things Up

Task	Tools to try
Graphics, reviews, offers	Canva (free plan) with reusable brand templates
Video editing	CapCut, or the built-in editors in Instagram and TikTok
Scheduling	Meta Business Suite (Facebook and Instagram), TikTok's built-in scheduler, or a scheduling app
Caption ideas and drafts	An AI assistant to brainstorm, then edit into your own voice
Idea storage	Your phone's notes app or a simple spreadsheet

Free plans and features change over time, so check what's included before you commit.

A caption formula you can reuse

CAPTION FORMULA

Hook (first line that stops the scroll) + **value or story** (2 to 4 short lines) + **local detail** (town, neighborhood or landmark) + **one call to action**.

Example: "This is why your drain keeps clogging. (Hook) Most blockages we find in Westside homes come from grease and wipes, not hair. A strainer and hot water once a week prevents most of them. (Value and local) Still stuck? Tap Call and we'll sort it today. (CTA)"

DO THIS TODAY

- Clean your lens and film one 15-second hands-only video of your work today.
- Choose one faceless format you're comfortable with and plan three posts using it.
- Block a recurring one-hour "content batch" slot in your calendar.
- Create 2 reusable templates in Canva: one for reviews, one for offers.
- Save the caption formula somewhere you'll see it every time you post.



MODULE 06

Getting Seen: Reach and the Algorithm

Fix the "I post and nothing happens" problem. Learn what makes people stop scrolling, which formats get shown to new people, and how to diagnose a post that flopped.

IN THIS MODULE

- 6.1 Writing hooks that stop the scroll
- 6.2 Formats that get the most reach
- 6.3 Posting frequency and timing
- 6.4 Diagnosing why your posts aren't working

6.1 Writing Hooks That Stop the Scroll

Algorithms watch what people do in the first moments of seeing your post. If they scroll past, fewer people are shown it. **The first 1 to 3 seconds of a video, and the first line of a caption, decide almost everything.**

- **Lead with the most interesting part.** Show the finished cake first, then how it was made.
- **Use movement in the first frame.** A static opening shot is easy to scroll past.
- **Put the hook on screen as text** too, since many people watch with the sound off.
- **Make it local.** Naming your town gets the attention of the people who matter most.

Hook templates to steal

Hook	Example
Local call-out	"If you live in Riverton, you need to know about this."
Mistake warning	"Stop doing this to your leather boots."
Curiosity	"This is what we found behind a Westside kitchen wall."
Price or value	"Here's what \$20 gets you at our bakery."
Common question	"The #1 question we get asked every single day..."
Result first	"From this... to this in 45 minutes."
Behind the scenes	"What really happens before we open at 7am."

6.2 Formats That Get the Most Reach

Different formats do different jobs. The mistake is using one format for everything.

Format	Best job	Use it for
Short vertical video (Reels, TikTok, Shorts)	Reaching people who don't follow you yet	Process, before/after, tips, behind-the-scenes
Carousels (multi-image posts)	Saves and shares	Step-by-step tips, lists, menus, transformations
Stories	Staying top of mind with existing followers	Daily updates, polls, availability, quick offers
Single photos	Showcasing products and your space	Product shots, Google profile updates, announcements
Live video	Deeper connection with loyal fans	Q&As, launches, events

Platforms regularly change what they favor. Short vertical video has been the strongest format for reaching new people for several years, but check your own insights every month. Your data tells you what works for *your* audience.

6.3 Posting Frequency and Timing

Consistency beats volume. Three good posts every week for a year will outperform a burst of daily posting that stops after three weeks. Choose a level you can actually sustain.

Level	Main platform	Stories	Google Business Profile
Minimum	2 posts per week	2 to 3 times per week	1 update per week
Good	3 to 4 posts per week	Most days	1 update plus new photos per week
Strong	5+ posts per week	Daily	2 updates plus new photos per week

When to post

- **Check your insights** for when your followers are most active. That beats any generic "best time to post" chart.
- **Match your customers' decision time.** A lunch spot should post late morning; a weekend brunch spot on Thursday or Friday; a trades business early evening when homeowners are at home noticing problems.
- **Stay around after posting.** Replying to comments in the first hour often helps a post reach more people.

6.4 Diagnosing Why Your Posts Aren't Working

Don't guess. Use this table to find the actual problem.

Symptom	Likely cause	Fix
Very low views	Weak hook or first frame; people scroll past	Start with movement and the result; add on-screen hook text
People start watching but leave quickly	Slow start or too long	Cut the intro; keep videos tight; change shots every 2 to 3 seconds
Views, but no likes or comments	No reason to engage	Ask a specific question; share an opinion; give a tip worth saving
Engagement, but no customers	No clear next step, or non-local audience	Add one clear CTA; mention your location; check audience locations
Followers dropping	Too much promotion, or inconsistent posting	Return to the 4 pillars; post on a steady schedule

Symptom	Likely cause	Fix
Good posts suddenly flop	Normal variation, or a format shift	Look at trends over a month, not single posts; test a different format

QUICK WIN

Once a month, find your 3 best-performing posts. What did they have in common? Make more of that. Find your 3 worst. Stop doing what they had in common.

DO THIS TODAY

- Rewrite the hooks of your next 3 posts using the templates above.
- Film at least one short vertical video this week.
- Pick a posting level (Minimum, Good or Strong) you can sustain for 3 months.
- Check your insights for when your followers are most active and schedule around it.
- Review your last 10 posts using the diagnosis table and write down your biggest problem.



MODULE 07

Turning Followers Into Customers

Likes don't pay the bills. Learn how to guide people from "that looks nice" to calling, booking and walking through your door.

IN THIS MODULE

- 7.1 Clear calls to action that get responses
- 7.2 Turning DMs and comments into bookings
- 7.3 Local offers and promotions that drive visits

7.1 Clear Calls to Action That Get Responses

A call to action (CTA) tells people exactly what to do next. Many local businesses post great content and never ask for anything. Viewers enjoy it, then scroll on and forget.

- **One CTA per post.** "Call, visit, book, or DM" is four choices, which usually means none.
- **Make it specific.** "Book your Saturday slot" beats "Contact us."
- **Make it easy.** Point people to the button or link, and make sure it works.
- **Match the CTA to the post.** Not every post needs a sales ask. Tip posts can ask for a save or share; promo posts ask for a booking.

Goal	Example CTA
Bookings	"We have 3 slots left this Friday. Tap Book in our profile."
Calls	"Burst pipe? Tap Call and we'll be there today."
Visits	"Come try it this weekend. Tap Directions, we're next to the library."
Messages	"Comment 'MENU' and we'll send you this week's specials."
Reach	"Send this to someone in Riverton who needs to know."
Saves	"Save this for the next time your sink clogs."

7.2 Turning DMs and Comments Into Bookings

Every message is a potential customer raising their hand. Slow or vague replies lose them to a competitor who answers first.

- **Reply fast.** Aim for within an hour during business hours. Turn on notifications for messages.
- **Set up saved replies** for the questions you get every day: prices, availability, location, parking.
- **Always end with a next step.** Never just answer a question and stop.
- **Answer price questions honestly.** If you can't give an exact price, give a range and explain why.
- **Move comments to messages** when the conversation gets specific: "Great question! Sending you a message now."

A 4-STEP DM SCRIPT

1. **Acknowledge:** "Hi Sarah, thanks for reaching out!"
2. **Answer:** "Yes, we do balayage. It usually runs \$180 to \$240 depending on hair length."
3. **Ask:** "Is this your first time having it done, or a refresh?"
4. **Close:** "We have openings Thursday at 10am or Saturday at 2pm. Want me to hold one for you?"

QUICK WIN

Put a small note by your phone or till: "Did they get a next step?" Every message, comment and call should end with a clear option to book, visit or buy.

7.3 Local Offers and Promotions That Drive Visits

Offers give people a reason to act now instead of "someday." The key is using them strategically, not permanently discounting your business.

Offer type	When to use it	Example
First-visit offer	To attract new customers	"Free coffee with your first pastry order"
Bring-a-friend	To turn customers into promoters	"Bring a friend, you both get 20% off"
Follower-only code	To track social results	"Say 'SAW IT ON INSTA' for a free topping"
Off-peak offer	To fill slow days or times	"Tuesday afternoons: kids' cuts \$5 off"
Seasonal special	To create urgency around a date	"Pumpkin menu, until October 31 only"
Bundle or package	To raise average spend	"Cut, color and blow-dry package"

- **Give every offer an end date** so people act now.
- **Make it trackable** with a code word, a specific booking link, or a question at checkout.
- **Avoid constant discounts.** Adding value (a free extra, a bundle, priority booking) protects your prices better than money off.

DO THIS TODAY

- Add one clear CTA to every post you publish this week.
- Write 3 saved replies for your most common questions.
- Turn on message notifications and commit to replying within an hour during business hours.
- Create one trackable offer with an end date and a code word.



MODULE 08

Reviews, Reputation and Community

Become the business your town talks about. Get more great reviews, handle the bad ones with confidence, and let customers and neighbors spread the word for you.

IN THIS MODULE

- 8.1** Systems for getting more reviews
- 8.2** Responding to negative reviews and comments
- 8.3** Partnering with nearby businesses and local creators
- 8.4** Encouraging customer-generated content

8.1 Systems for Getting More Reviews

Reviews are often the deciding factor between you and a competitor, and they help you appear in local search. Most happy customers are willing to leave one. They just need to be asked, at the right time, in an easy way.

- **Ask at the moment of peak happiness:** when they compliment you, see the finished result, or thank you.
- **Make it easy:** use your direct Google review link and turn it into a QR code for your counter, receipts and business cards.
- **Follow up:** send a short text or email within 24 hours with the link.
- **Train your team** to ask too, and celebrate new reviews together.
- **Keep it steady:** a regular flow of recent reviews builds more trust than a burst once a year.

REVIEW REQUEST SCRIPTS

In person: "I'm so glad you love it! Would you mind leaving us a quick Google review? It really helps a small business like ours. Here's the QR code."

By text: "Hi Tom, thanks for choosing us today! If you have a minute, a quick review would mean a lot: [link]. Thanks, Maria at Riverside Plumbing."

IMPORTANT

Don't offer discounts, gifts or prizes in exchange for reviews, and don't only ask customers you think will leave positive ones. This can break Google's review policies and consumer protection rules, and can get reviews removed.

8.2 Responding to Negative Reviews and Comments

Every business eventually gets a bad review. Future customers read your reply more closely than the complaint itself. A calm, professional response can actually increase trust.

THE RESPONSE FORMULA

1. Thank them for the feedback. **2. Acknowledge** their experience without arguing. **3. Apologize** for how it felt. **4. Take it offline** with a way to contact you. **5. Fix it** privately if you can.

EXAMPLE REPLY

"Hi Jen, thank you for letting us know. We're sorry your order was late on Saturday. That's not the experience we want for anyone. We'd like to make it right, so please call us at 555-0123 and ask for Sam.
— Sam, Owner"

- **Reply within a day or two**, but never in anger. Wait, reread, then respond.
- **Never share private details** about the customer or their visit. This is especially important for health, legal and financial businesses.
- **Report fake or abusive reviews** through the platform's flag or report option.
- **Reply to positive reviews too.** A short, personal thank-you shows you care and encourages more reviews.
- **For nasty comments on your posts**, reply once politely, move it to private messages, and hide or delete only genuine abuse or spam.

8.3 Partnering With Nearby Businesses and Local Creators

Other local businesses already have the audience you want. Partnering puts you in front of them at no cost, and makes you look like a real part of the community.

- **Cross-promote with complementary businesses:** the florist and the bakery, the gym and the smoothie bar, the salon and the bridal shop.
- **Create joint content:** use collaboration posts (on Instagram, one post shows on both accounts), joint giveaways with local pickup, or "a day on our street" videos.
- **Work with local creators:** smaller local accounts with engaged audiences in your town often bring better results than big accounts. Invite them in, pay them fairly or offer a fair exchange, and make sure the partnership is clearly disclosed.
- **Show up in the community:** sponsor a school event or youth team, host a charity day, or join a local business network. Then share it.

8.4 Encouraging Customer-Generated Content

Photos and videos from real customers are some of the most trusted content you can share. They also save you time.

- **Make it easy to share:** put your handle and a local hashtag on receipts, packaging, cups, menus and signs.
- **Create a photo moment:** a mural, a neon sign, a great-looking plate, or a "just got my hair done" mirror.
- **Ask directly:** "Tag us if you post it! We love sharing our customers."
- **Always ask permission** before reposting, and credit the customer.
- **Feature a "customer of the month"** to show people you appreciate them.

DO THIS TODAY

- Get your direct Google review link and turn it into a QR code for your counter.
- Pick one review request script and use it with every happy customer this week.
- Reply to every unanswered review, positive and negative, using the response formula.
- List 3 complementary local businesses and message one about a collaboration.
- Add your social handle and hashtag to receipts, packaging or signage.



MODULE 09

Small-Budget Ads and Measuring What Works

Spend a little on ads without wasting it, and find out which of your efforts are actually bringing in customers.

IN THIS MODULE

- 9.1 Boosted posts vs. real ads
- 9.2 Setting up a geo-targeted ad on a small budget
- 9.3 Key metrics to track
- 9.4 Simple ways to connect social media to actual sales

9.1 Boosted Posts vs. Real Ads

Many business owners' first ad experience is hitting "Boost" and wondering where the money went. Boosting isn't bad, but it's important to know the difference.

	Boosted post	Ads Manager campaign
What it is	Paying to show an existing post to more people	A full ad set up in the platform's ad tool
Setup time	About 2 minutes	15 to 30 minutes
Control	Basic audience, budget and goal options	Detailed goals, placements, audience, testing
Best for	Promoting a post that's already doing well, local events, awareness	Specific goals like calls, messages, bookings or traffic

GOLDEN RULE

Never boost a post that flopped organically. Only put money behind posts that already got good engagement from locals. It's proof that the content works.

9.2 Setting Up a Geo-Targeted Ad on a Small Budget

A small, well-targeted local ad can work on a modest budget. Here's a simple test you can run.

Step	What to do
1. Choose one goal	Calls, messages, website visits, bookings, or local awareness. One goal per campaign.
2. Set your area	Target a radius around your business based on how far customers realistically travel: a few miles for a cafe, wider for a service business that drives to clients.
3. Keep the audience broad	Within your area, don't over-narrow with dozens of interests. The platform usually finds the right people better with a wider pool.
4. Use proven creative	Your best-performing organic post or video, with a clear local hook and one CTA.
5. Set a test budget	Start with a small daily amount you're comfortable losing, and run it for about 7 days.
6. Judge on cost per result	Look at cost per call, message or booking, not likes. Compare it to what a new customer is worth to you.
7. Keep, tweak or stop	If it's profitable, keep going or increase slowly. If not, change one thing (creative, offer or area) and test again.

Ads for housing, employment, credit and some other categories have special targeting restrictions on many platforms. Check the rules if your business falls into one of these areas.

WHAT IS A CUSTOMER WORTH?

Know your numbers before spending. If an average customer spends \$60 per visit and comes back 5 times a year, each new customer is worth about \$300 a year. Paying \$20 to \$30 to win one could be a great deal. Without knowing this, you can't tell if an ad is working.

9.3 Key Metrics to Track

Ignore vanity metrics and focus on the numbers that show people moving toward buying.

Metric	Where to find it	Why it matters
Calls from your profile	Google Business Profile performance, social insights	Direct sign of buying intent
Direction requests	Google Business Profile performance	People planning to visit
Website and booking clicks	Profile insights, booking tool	People taking the next step
Messages received	Inbox, insights	Warm leads you can convert
Reach and local share	Insights: reach and top locations	Whether the right people are seeing you
Saves and shares	Post insights	Content people value and spread
Offer redemptions	Your till, booking system, code tracking	Direct proof social brought in sales
"How did you hear about us?"	Checkout, booking or intake form	The simplest, most honest measure of all

9.4 Simple Ways to Connect Social Media to Actual Sales

- **Ask every new customer** how they found you, and record the answer.
- **Use code words or unique offers** for each platform ("INSTA10," "Mention TikTok").
- **Use tracked links** (such as links with UTM tags, or a separate booking link) for social, so your website or booking tool shows where visits came from.
- **Compare busy periods** to your posting and ad activity.
- **Review once a month** using the scorecard below. Fifteen minutes is enough.

Monthly scorecard

Measure	This month	Last month	Notes
Posts published			
Local share of audience (%)			
Calls + direction requests			
Messages received			
New reviews			
Customers who said "social media"			
Offer redemptions			
Ad spend / cost per result			

At the end of the review, ask three questions: **What worked? What didn't? What's one thing I'll change next month?**

DO THIS TODAY

- Work out roughly what one new customer is worth to your business per year.
- Pick your best organic post from the last month as a candidate for a small ad test.
- Set up one trackable link or code word for your main social platform.
- Print or copy the monthly scorecard and fill in this month's numbers.
- Put a 15-minute monthly review in your calendar.

Your 90-Day Growth Roadmap

This is your week-by-week plan for the next 90 days. Expect to spend about 2 to 4 hours a week, including your weekly content batch. Each week points to the module that explains the details, and each 30-day phase ends with a check-in so you can see your progress and adjust.

BEFORE YOU START

Before Week 1, fill in the monthly scorecard from Module 9 with today's numbers: local share of your audience, calls and direction requests, messages, total reviews, and how many customers mention social media. These are your Day 1 baseline.

Phase 1: Days 1 to 30 — Build the Foundation

Get the basics right so every post you make later has somewhere to send people.

Week	Focus	Tasks
Week 1	Know your customer (M1)	Complete the seven-question customer profile. Ask 10 regular customers how they found you. Add "How did you hear about us?" to checkout or booking. Join 2 or 3 local online groups.
Week 2	Platforms and Google (M2)	Claim and fully complete your Google Business Profile. Choose your one main social platform. Pause accounts you can't keep active.
Week 3	Profiles (M3)	Rewrite your bio with the local formula. Add local keywords. Make your name, address and phone number match everywhere. Set up contact buttons and run the 60-second test.
Week 4	Start posting (M4)	Set up your 4 content pillars and phone ideas note. List local events for the next 3 months. Publish your first 3 posts.

CHECK-IN

Day 30: Is your Google profile complete? Can a stranger book or contact you within 60 seconds? Have you posted at least 3 times? Fill in the scorecard and compare it to Day 1.

Phase 2: Days 31 to 60 — Create and Get Seen

Build a content habit you can sustain, then make sure the right local people see it.

Week	Focus	Tasks
Week 5	Content system (M5)	Book a weekly one-hour batching slot. Create Canva templates for reviews and offers. Do your first full batch and schedule a week of posts.
Week 6	Hooks and video (M6)	Rewrite your hooks using the templates. Film and post your first short vertical videos. Choose a posting level you can sustain.
Week 7	Test and engage (M5, M6)	Try 2 formats you haven't used yet, such as a faceless video or a carousel. Reply to every comment within the first hour of posting.
Week 8	Diagnose and improve (M6)	Review your posts with the diagnosis table. Find your 3 best and 3 worst posts. Do more of what worked and drop what didn't.

CHECK-IN

Day 60: Have you posted consistently at your chosen level? Is your local audience share rising? Which formats and topics get the most reach? Fill in the scorecard and compare it to Day 30.

Phase 3: Days 61 to 90 — Convert and Grow

Turn attention into customers, build your reputation, and start measuring real results.

Week	Focus	Tasks
Week 9	Convert (M7)	Add one clear call to action to every post. Write saved replies for common questions. Launch one trackable offer with an end date.
Week 10	Reviews (M8)	Create your review QR code. Ask every happy customer for a review. Reply to every review, positive and negative.
Week 11	Community (M8)	Contact one complementary local business about a collaboration. Add your handle to receipts and signs. Reshare customer content with permission.
Week 12	Ads (M9)	Work out what a customer is worth to you. Run a small 7-day geo-targeted test using your best organic post, with a tracked link or code.
Week 13	Measure and plan (M9)	Fill in the full scorecard. Compare Day 90 with Day 1. Decide what to keep, stop and try next.

CHECK-IN

Day 90: How many new customers came from social media? How much did reviews, calls and messages grow? Which three actions made the biggest difference? Use the answers to plan your next 90 days.

The five habits that matter most

- **Show up consistently** at a level you can sustain.
- **Talk to locals**, not the whole internet.
- **Document real work** instead of trying to create perfect content.
- **Always give people a next step** to book, call or visit.
- **Ask for reviews** from every happy customer, every time.

A final word

You don't need to become an influencer. You need to become the obvious choice in your town for what you do. That happens one helpful post, one quick reply, and one happy customer at a time.

Start with today's checklist. Small, consistent actions compound faster than you'd expect.



About the Author

Andrew Corter is the founder and CEO of **Corter Digital**, a media company built to help small businesses grow.

Corter Digital focuses on the challenges local business owners face every day: limited time, limited budgets, and marketing advice that wasn't written for them. This guide brings that practical, results-first approach into one step-by-step playbook that any owner can follow.

WANT HELP GROWING YOUR BUSINESS?

If you'd rather have an expert team in your corner, Corter Digital helps small businesses turn social media into real customers.

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